

IRANIAN & MACEDONIAN INVASIONS

NORTH-WESTERN CONTACT ZONE AND → ACHAEMENID INCLUSION: CLAIM, REACH → ACHAEMENID MECHANISMS IN THE → KHAROSTHI AND ARAMAIC: TRANSMISSION → ALEXANDER'S ROUTE: FROM ACHAEMENID → HYDASPES: BATTLE MECHANISM AND

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g4 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 NORTH-WESTERN CONTACT ZONE AND EVIDENCE LADDER

NORTH-WESTERN CONTACT ZONE AND EVIDENCE LADDER CENTRAL ASIA HINDU KUSH PUNJAB RIVERS ARMIES + MERCHANTS + ENVOYS + SCRIPTS + COIN ROYAL INSCRIPTION NEAR-SOURCE REPORT LATER NARRATIVE

IRAN / CENTRAL ASIA

Hindu Kush → Kabul-Gandhara → Indus → Taxila → Punjab rivers

armies + merchants + envoys + scripts + coin forms

EVIDENCE: royal inscription → archaeology → near-source report → later narrative

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- IRAN / CENTRAL ASIA
- Hindu Kush → Kabul-Gandhara → Indus → Taxila → Punjab rivers

METHOD / DEBATE

- armies + merchants + envoys + scripts + coin forms
- EVIDENCE: royal inscription → archaeology → near-source report → later narrative

HISTORICAL RESULT

- RULE: geography enabled contact; imperial capacity and local politics shaped outcomes.
- LIMIT: north-western campaigns must not be written as conquest of all India.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RULE: geography enabled contact; imperial capacity and local politics shaped outcomes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: geography enabled contact; imperial capacity and local politics shaped outcomes.

01

STAGE 01 ACHAEMENID INCLUSION: CLAIM, REACH AND LIMITS

ACHAEMENID INCLUSION CLAIM, REACH AND LIMITS DARIUS DNA XERXES XPH GANDARA + HIDUSH NAMED AMONG SUBJECT COUNTRIES TRIBUTE DISTRICT + INDIAN/GANDARIAN CONTINGENTS IMPERIAL CLAIM, EXTRACTION AND MILITARY CONNECTION NOT SECURE

DARIUS DNa / XERXES XPh

Gandara + Hidush named among subject countries

Herodotus: tribute district + Indian/Gandarian contingents

SECURE: imperial claim, extraction and military connection

NOT SECURE: uniform borders, equal control or audited tribute totals

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- DARIUS DNa / XERXES XPh
- Gandara + Hidush named among subject countries

METHOD / DEBATE

- Herodotus: tribute district + Indian/Gandarian contingents
- SECURE: imperial claim, extraction and military connection

HISTORICAL RESULT

- NOT SECURE: uniform borders, equal control or audited tribute totals
- DARIUS DNa / XERXES XPh

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: NOT SECURE: uniform borders, equal control or audited tribute totals.

02

STAGE 02 ACHAEMENID MECHANISMS IN THE INDUS FRONTIER

ACHAEMENID MECHANISMS IN THE INDUS FRONTIER IMPERIAL EXPANSION SATRAPAL MEDIATION + TRIBUTE + GARRISONS + POSSIBLE LEGACIES ARAMAIC-KHAROSTHI LINK, COIN FORMS, POLITICAL VOCABULARY CONTACT PRECEDENT IS NOT PROOF THAT MAURYAN INSTITUTIONS WERE

IMPERIAL EXPANSION satrapal mediation + tribute + garrisons + roads +

multilingual administration north-west linked more closely to Iranian imperial circuits

POSSIBLE LEGACIES: Aramaic-Kharosthi link, coin forms, political vocabulary

CAUTION: contact precedent is not proof that Mauryan institutions were copied.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- IMPERIAL EXPANSION satrapal mediation + tribute + garrisons + roads +
- multilingual administration north-west linked more closely to Iranian imperial circuits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- POSSIBLE LEGACIES: Aramaic-Kharosthi link, coin forms, political vocabulary
- CAUTION: contact precedent is not proof that Mauryan institutions were copied.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- IMPERIAL EXPANSION satrapal mediation + tribute + garrisons + roads +
- multilingual administration north-west linked more closely to Iranian imperial circuits

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: contact precedent is not proof that Mauryan institutions were copied.

03

STAGE 03 KHAROSTHI AND ARAMAIC: TRANSMISSION WITHOUT COPYING

KHAROSTHI AND ARAMAIC TRANSMISSION WITHOUT COPYING ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT KHAROSTHI RIGHT-TO-LEFT SCRIPT LOCAL LANGUAGE USE ACHAEMENID CONTACT LIKELY AIDED TRANSMISSION EARLIEST EXTENSIVE SECURE INDIAN CORPUS IS MAURYAN/ASHOKAN AND NORTH-WESTERN.

ORIGIN PROCESS DATE OF SURVIVING INSCRIPTIONS.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use
Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Earliest extensive secure Indian corpus is Mauryan/Ashokan and north-western.
DISTINCTION: origin process != date of surviving inscriptions.

DEBATE / LEGACY

ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use
Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission

03

STAGE 03 KHAROSTHI AND ARAMAIC: TRANSMISSION WITHOUT COPYING

KHAROSTHI AND ARAMAIC TRANSMISSION WITHOUT COPYING ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT KHAROSTHI RIGHT-TO-LEFT SCRIPT LOCAL LANGUAGE USE ACHAEMENID CONTACT LIKELY AIDED TRANSMISSION EARLIEST EXTENSIVE SECURE INDIAN CORPUS IS MAURYAN/ASHOKAN AND NORTH-WESTERN.

ORIGIN PROCESS DATE OF SURVIVING INSCRIPTIONS.

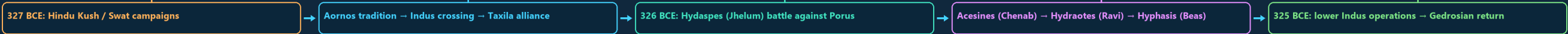
POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use	Earliest extensive secure Indian corpus is Mauryan/Ashokan and north-western.	ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use
Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission	DISTINCTION: origin process != date of surviving inscriptions.	Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission
POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY - ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use - Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM - Earliest extensive secure Indian corpus is Mauryan/Ashokan and north-western. - DISTINCTION: origin process != date of surviving inscriptions.	DEBATE / LEGACY - ARAMAIC IMPERIAL ENVIRONMENT → ADAPTATION → KHAROSTHI right-to-left script local language use - Achaemenid contact likely aided transmission

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DISTINCTION: origin process != date of surviving inscriptions.

04

STAGE 04 ALEXANDER'S ROUTE: FROM ACHAEMENID WORLD TO PUNJAB

ALEXANDER'S ROUTE FROM ACHAEMENID WORLD TO PUNJAB 327 BCE HINDU KUSH SWAT CAMPAIGNS AORNOS TRADITION INDUS CROSSING TAXILA ALLIANCE



CHRONOLOGY / PHASE 327 BCE: Hindu Kush / Swat campaigns - Aornos tradition → Indus crossing → Taxila alliance 326 BCE: Hydaspes (Jhelum) battle against Porus	MATERIAL / INSTITUTION - Acesines (Chenab) → Hydraotes (Ravi) → Hyphasis (Beas) 325 BCE: lower Indus operations → Gedrosian return - ROUTE RULE: several passes and valleys mattered; Khyber was not the only road.	IMPACT / LIMIT - SITE RULE: Bhir belongs to early Taxila; Sirkap is later Indo-Greek. - SOURCE RULE: surviving campaign narratives are later than the events.
--	--	--

MECHANISM / VERDICT — SOURCE RULE: surviving campaign narratives are later than the events.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: surviving campaign narratives are later than the events.

05

STAGE 05 HYDASPES: BATTLE MECHANISM AND POLITICAL SETTLEMENT

BATTLE MECHANISM AND POLITICAL SETTLEMENT RIVER + MONSOON + PORUS'S ELEPHANTS CONCEALED CROSSING FLANK PRESSURE CLOSE BATTLE MACEDONIAN VICTORY PORUS RESTORED AND ENLARGED AS SUBORDINATE REGIONAL RULER

CONSERVE MANPOWER + RETAIN LOCAL LEGITIMACY + CREATE A FAMOUS DIALOGUE AND EXACT TACTICS COME THROUGH LATER LITERARY



POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY - RIVER + MONSOON + PORUS'S ELEPHANTS concealed crossing → flank pressure → close battle → Macedonian victory - Porus restored and enlarged as subordinate regional ruler	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM - MECHANISM: conserve manpower + retain local legitimacy + create a buffer - LIMIT: famous dialogue and exact tactics come through later literary shaping.	DEBATE / LEGACY - RIVER + MONSOON + PORUS'S ELEPHANTS concealed crossing → flank pressure → close battle → Macedonian victory - Porus restored and enlarged as subordinate regional ruler
---	--	--

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: famous dialogue and exact tactics come through later literary shaping.

06

STAGE 06 WHY THE ARMY STOPPED AT THE BEAS

WHY THE ARMY STOPPED AT THE BEAS BEAS HALT ACCUMULATED CASUALTIES AND CAMPAIGN FATIGUE MONSOON, RIVERS DIMINISHING CONFIDENCE IN UNLIMITED ADVANCE A CUMULATIVE MILITARY-LOGISTICAL-POLITICAL REFUSAL, NOT ONE FEAR FACTOR.

NANDA ARMY FIGURES ARE REMEMBERED SCALE, NOT AUDITED STATISTICS.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports	diminishing confidence in unlimited advance	LIMIT: Nanda army figures are remembered scale, not audited statistics.
of strong eastern armies and elephants soldiers' bargaining power after years of service	VERDICT: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.	BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports
POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY - BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports - of strong eastern armies and elephants soldiers' bargaining power after years of service	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM - diminishing confidence in unlimited advance - VERDICT: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.	DEBATE / LEGACY - LIMIT: Nanda army figures are remembered scale, not audited statistics. - BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports

NANDA ARMY FIGURES ARE REMEMBERED SCALE, NOT AUDITED STATISTICS.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports	diminishing confidence in unlimited advance	LIMIT: Nanda army figures are remembered scale, not audited statistics.
of strong eastern armies and elephants soldiers' bargaining power after years of service	VERDICT: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.	BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports
- of strong eastern armies and elephants soldiers' bargaining power after years of service

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- diminishing confidence in unlimited advance
- VERDICT: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- LIMIT: Nanda army figures are remembered scale, not audited statistics.
- BEAS HALT accumulated casualties and campaign fatigue monsoon, rivers, distance and supply strain reports

MECHANISM / VERDICT

VERDICT: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: a cumulative military-logistical-political refusal, not one fear factor.

07

STAGE 07

LOCAL AGENCY: ALLIANCE, RESISTANCE AND NEGOTIATED RULE

LOCAL AGENCY

ALLIANCE, RESISTANCE AND NEGOTIATED RULE

TAXILA PORUS

HYDASPES MALLOI AND OTHERS ALLIANCE AND LOGISTICS ARMED RESISTANCE

LOCAL POLITICAL AGENCY

EXTERNAL CONQUEST ADVANCED THROUGH EXISTING CONFLICTS, NOT ACROSS AN

ALLIANCE WAS STRATEGIC CHOICE; RESISTANCE VARIED BY POLITY AND

DO NOT REDUCE NORTH-WESTERN SOCIETY TO PASSIVE VICTIMS OR

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
AMBHI / TAXILA PORUS / HYDASPES MALLOI AND OTHERS alliance and logistics armed	LOCAL POLITICAL AGENCY	Alliance was strategic choice; resistance varied by polity and terrain.
resistance fortified resistance rivalry used externally defeat then restoration severe local fighting	External conquest advanced through existing conflicts, not across an empty frontier.	Do not reduce north-western society to passive victims or willing collaborators.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AMBHI / TAXILA PORUS / HYDASPES MALLOI AND OTHERS alliance and logistics armed
- resistance fortified resistance rivalry used externally defeat then restoration severe local fighting

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- LOCAL POLITICAL AGENCY
- External conquest advanced through existing conflicts, not across an empty frontier.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Alliance was strategic choice; resistance varied by polity and terrain.
- Do not reduce north-western society to passive victims or willing collaborators.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Do not reduce north-western society to passive victims or willing collaborators.

08

STAGE 08

CONSEQUENCES: DIRECT, INDIRECT AND OVERCLAIMED

DIRECT, INDIRECT AND OVERCLAIMED

SHORT-LIVED MACEDONIAN GARRISONS, SATRAPIES, ROUTE KNOWLEDGE, NAVAL SURVEY

POWER REORDERING IN THE NORTH-WEST AND SUCCESSOR CONFLICTS

LONGER CONTACT

COINAGE, ART AND DIPLOMACY THROUGH LATER HELLENISTIC POLITIES

NOT DIRECT

MAURYAN EMPIRE, INDO-GREEK RULE, GANDHARA ART CENTURIES LATER

ANSWER BY CHRONOLOGY

DIRECT: short-lived Macedonian garrisons, satrapies, route knowledge, naval survey

NEAR-TERM: power reordering in the north-west and successor conflicts

LONGER CONTACT: coinage, art and diplomacy through later Hellenistic polities

NOT DIRECT: Mauryan empire, Indo-Greek rule, Gandhara art centuries later

Answer by chronology: event → mechanism → later transmission → explicit limit.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
DIRECT: short-lived Macedonian garrisons, satrapies, route knowledge, naval survey	LONGER CONTACT: coinage, art and diplomacy through later Hellenistic polities	Answer by chronology: event → mechanism → later transmission → explicit limit.
NEAR-TERM: power reordering in the north-west and successor conflicts	NOT DIRECT: Mauryan empire, Indo-Greek rule, Gandhara art centuries later	Avoid 'opened India to the West'; the corridor already had older connections.

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Answer by chronology: event → mechanism → later transmission → explicit limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Mauryan empire, Indo-Greek rule, Gandhara art centuries later.

09

STAGE 09

MAURYAN AND SELEUCID BRIDGE

MAURYAN AND SELEUCID BRIDGE

ALEXANDER'S DEATH (323 BCE)

UNSTABLE SATRAPIES AND SUCCESSOR STRUGGLES

CHANDRAGUPTA'S NORTH-WESTERN EXPANSION

SELEUCUS CONFLICT AND TREATY, C. 305-301 BCE

TERRITORIAL ADJUSTMENT + DIPLOMATIC EXCHANGE

LATER-QUOTED OBSERVER AT THE MAURYAN COURT

MACEDONIAN WITHDRAWAL CREATED OPPORTUNITY, NOT AUTOMATIC MAURYAN VICTORY.

ALEXANDER'S DEATH (323 BCE)

unstable satrapies and successor struggles

Chandragupta's north-western expansion

Seleucus conflict and treaty, c. 305-301 BCE

territorial adjustment + diplomatic exchange

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE	MATERIAL / INSTITUTION	IMPACT / LIMIT
ALEXANDER'S DEATH (323 BCE)	Seleucus conflict and treaty, c. 305-301 BCE	BRIDGE: Macedonian withdrawal created opportunity, not automatic Mauryan victory.
unstable satrapies and successor struggles	territorial adjustment + diplomatic exchange	BOUNDARY: detailed Mauryan administration belongs to Topic 14.
Chandragupta's north-western expansion	MEGASTHENES: later-quoted observer at the Mauryan court	

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: BOUNDARY: detailed Mauryan administration belongs to Topic 14.

IRANIAN & MACEDONIAN INVASIONS • TILE 3/4 • same master rows 5495-8729 of 11476 • continues below

ALEXANDER'S DEATH (323 BCE)

→

unstable satrapies and successor struggles

→

Chandragupta's north-western expansion

→

Seleucus conflict and treaty, c. 305-301 BCE

→

territorial adjustment + diplomatic exchange

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- ALEXANDER'S DEATH (323 BCE)
- unstable satrapies and successor struggles
- Chandragupta's north-western expansion

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- Seleucus conflict and treaty, c. 305-301 BCE
- territorial adjustment + diplomatic exchange
- MEGASTHENES: later-quoted observer at the Mauryan court

IMPACT / LIMIT

- BRIDGE: Macedonian withdrawal created opportunity, not automatic Mauryan victory.
- BOUNDARY: detailed Mauryan administration belongs to Topic 14.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: BOUNDARY: detailed Mauryan administration belongs to Topic 14.

10

STAGE 10

PRELIMS DISTINCTION GRID

PRELIMS DISTINCTION GRID

JHELMUM HYPHASIS

CHENAB HYDRAOTES

EARLIEST HISTORIC TAXILA PHASE

LATER HELLENISTIC-GRID CITY; SIRSUKH

KUSHANA PHASE

ROYAL COUNTRY LISTS; HERODOTUS

GREEK NARRATIVE

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

DEBATE / LEGACY

Hydaspes = Jhelum Hyphasis = Beas

Sirkap = later Hellenistic-grid city; Sirsukh = Kushana phase

Kharosthi = right-to-left; Aramaic linkage, not Alexander's invention

Acesines = Chenab Hydraotes = Ravi

DNa/XPh = royal country lists; Herodotus = Greek narrative

TRAP FILTER: date + source class + geography + degree of certainty.

Bhir = earliest historic Taxila phase

Arrian = later writer using lost earlier accounts

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Hydaspes = Jhelum Hyphasis = Beas
- Acesines = Chenab Hydraotes = Ravi
- Bhir = earliest historic Taxila phase

- Sirkap = later Hellenistic-grid city; Sirsukh = Kushana phase
- DNa/XPh = royal country lists; Herodotus = Greek narrative
- Arrian = later writer using lost earlier accounts

- Kharosthi = right-to-left; Aramaic linkage, not Alexander's invention
- TRAP FILTER: date + source class + geography + degree of certainty.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: date + source class + geography + degree of certainty.

11

STAGE 11

EXAMINER-READY INVASION ANSWER SPINE

EXAMINER-READY INVASION ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE THE NORTH-WESTERN SCALE AND SEPARATE IRANIAN FROM MACEDONIAN

BODY 1

GEOGRAPHY AND LOCAL POLITIES

BODY 2

ACHAEMENID INSCRIPTION/TEXT EVIDENCE AND ADMINISTRATIVE CONTACT

BODY 3

ALEXANDER ROUTE, HYDASPES SETTLEMENT AND BEAS HALT

INTRO: define the north-western scale and separate Iranian from Macedonian phases.

→

BODY 1: geography and local polities

→

BODY 2: Achaemenid inscription/text evidence and administrative contact

→

BODY 3: Alexander route, Hydaspes settlement and Beas halt

→

BODY 4: direct consequences versus later Hellenistic developments

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

DEBATE / LEGACY

- INTRO: define the north-western scale and separate Iranian from Macedonian phases.
- BODY 1: geography and local polities
- BODY 2: Achaemenid inscription/text evidence and administrative contact

- BODY 3: Alexander route, Hydaspes settlement and Beas halt
- BODY 4: direct consequences versus later Hellenistic developments
- COUNTER: source distance, uncertain borders and exaggerated figures

- CONCLUSION: connected frontier + local agency + selective institutional effects
- WRITE: claim → named evidence → mechanism → significance → limit.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — WRITE: claim → named evidence → mechanism → significance → limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: connected frontier + local agency + selective institutional effects.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA

2. KEY CLASSIFICATION

3. STUDY LINKS

4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)

5. UPSC TRAPS

6. CURRENT LINK

7. MAINS ANGLES

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

ADVANCED DEBATE

LEGACY / NUANCE

- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data
- 3. Study links

- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link
- 7. Mains angles

- The invasion "briefly grazed" the north-western rim of the subcontinent and did not create a major long-term empire in India.
- Its concrete results included a Seleucid principality in the north-west and Greek settlements such as Boukephala, Nikaia and several Alexandrias .
- The political map showed multiple systems: monarchies, oligarchic groups and tribal principalities.
- The fragmented north-west helps explain both Alexander's advance and the later Mauryan opportunity.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.